comfortable for several months as I plodded along typing in the library. The delightful students of TISS Hyderabad provided valuable assistance in collecting a hundred precious migration histories in Ratnagiri district. The students and ‘history interns’ of IIMA provided a great source of intellectual stimulation by asking seemingly naïve but intensely thought-provoking questions. They include Devika Kerkar, Anusha Rajan, Harini Alladi, Shobhit Shubhankar, Shashank Krishnakumar, Amish Sarpotdar, Deepti Raj, Shayoni Mukherjee, Kirthika Ashokkumar and Sandeep Badole. Above all, I would like to thank the numerous migrant workers I have interacted with, across India and abroad, in buses, boats and general compartments of trains, on railway platforms, at airports and worksites and homes, for sharing their life histories with me.

I am grateful to my schoolteacher, Jayant Tengshe (JT) for inculcating the spirit of inquiry; Rupa Chanda for nurturing my doctoral research on migration; Tirthankar Roy for inspiring my foray into history; and Arvind Subramanian for kindly agreeing to write the foreword of this book. My friends and family members—Nandini Huzurbazar, Raajasi Huzurbazar, Varad Huzurbazar, Sailaja Ravindranath, C.R. Ravindranath, Mohan Tumbe, Anuradha Tumbe, Krishnaraj Tumbe, Lalitha Surabhi—and colleagues at various institutions have been extremely supportive of my research, egging me on to write a book that they can read. To meet this challenge, I owe a great debt to the wonderful team at Penguin Random House India and Swati Chopra’s incredible enthusiasm for carefully attending to my queries and believing in me to write this book.

Divya has seen this book ‘move’ at varying speeds and, true to her name, was the shining light of inspiration behind it. My son, Siddhartha, began to read and write at the same time that I started working on this book. Strangely, I now empathize with his experience of being a first-time writer. I learnt almost everything in life from my parents—Sudha Huzurbazar and Vasudev Tumbe—whose love story began in an iconic symbol of Indian migration: the train. They are both light sleepers with a good sense of humour and hence I dedicate this book to them, and their sleep.